

Main

**Report Name (Org\_Country\_Year\_Report Type)**

Baylor Malawi\_Malawi\_2024-25\_3-month Report

**Fellowship Organization**

Baylor (formerly Baylor International Pediatric AIDS Initiative (BIPAI))

**Fellowship City**

Lilongwe

**Fellowship Country**

Malawi

**Fellowship Start Date**

07/09/2024

**Anticipated Fellowship End Date**

07/12/2024

**What is your fellowship title/role?**

Program support officer

**What are your primary responsibilities?**

Develops and monitors fundraising strategies, prepares grant submissions, and maintains tracking databases. Establishes and manages partnerships with CSOs, governments, and the private sector, leading advocacy and policy engagement efforts. Assists in planning and executing key activities at Kamuzu Central Hospital, including cancer camps, pediatric oncology therapy, and various health awareness events. Creates and implements communication materials, including newsletters, brochures, and social media content to support fundraising and outreach.

**I receive adequate direction and support to perform my fellowship responsibilities.**

Disagree

**Did you receive any sort of orientation, handover or onboarding when you started your fellowship?**

No

**Please describe your orientation/onboarding and note who handled it.**

**If you did not receive any kind of orientation, what information or guidance were you provided at the start of your fellowship?**

I was told my first quarter tasks and introduced to the team. I requested an orientation/onboarding but did not receive one.

**Describe a representative day at work.**

At work I usually work independently on longterm projects and then have a few meetings with team members from the ward to collaborate on specific aspects of the projects. I try to spend some time in the clinics too. Sometimes I am working on photography/interviews there or shadowing rounds with the clinicians.

**On average, how many hours per week do you work?**

41

**How would you describe your effectiveness in your fellowship post so far?**

Neutral

**Please briefly describe 1-2 specific projects that you have undertaken or accomplishments you have made so far.**

So far I have completed donor mapping, developed a communications and donor relations strategy for the year and presented it to the team for feedback.

**What is your organization's work culture like?**

**What is your office environment like? Please comment on the size and structure of the office(s) where you do most of your work.**

My time is split between two locations, the Pediatric Hematology and Oncology ward (Global HOPE PHO, 3 days a week) and an HIV clinic (the Baylor Center of Excellence/COE, 2 days a week). For both, I am in offices that are located next to the clinic, and collaborate with team members who focus on clinical service delivery as well as administration. The COE offices consist of 30+ people, but most of our tasks are independent. At the PHO, there are only a handful of people regularly based in the offices, but the team spread across the nearby lab, pharmacy and clinic is substantial.

**To whom do you report?**

I report to the program manager.

**Have you had an initial check-in with your supervisor to set up a work plan and to set goals for your work during your fellowship year?**

Yes

**Was this meeting helpful in understanding your role and setting goals for your fellowship year?**

Kind of

**Please explain why you have not met with your supervisor and if you have plans to do so going forward.**

**Please briefly indicate 3-5 professional goals you have for the rest of your fellowship year. Your professional goals should align with your work plan.**

My professional goals include getting more familiar with project development and the general navigation of the work environment, and gain more experience applying for grant opportunities.

**How often do you check in with your supervisor?**

Irregularly

**Have you had an opportunity to travel for work so far?**

No

**Describe this travel opportunity. Include location(s) and a brief description of the purpose of the trip(s).**

**I feel adequately prepared for my position's professional responsibilities.**

Agree

**Please briefly explain your response.**

My experience working on similar projects in a range of different NGOs has prepared me well for my tasks here.

**How did you travel to your host country and site? Please be specific**

I purchased a one way ticket from Larnaca, Cyprus to Lilongwe, Malawi directly through Ethiopian Airlines for \$797. The flight path was from Larnaca to Athens, then to Addis Ababa, then to Lilongwe. I found the ticket through Google Flights.

**What kind of visa/ permit do you have or applied for?**

I have a work permit.

**How did you obtain (or are obtaining) your visa or permit?**

Baylor organized it, but it took them 7 months.

**Did you apply for and receive your visa / permit before heading to your host country or after arriving?**

Received after arriving

**What costs were associated with obtaining your visa or permit?**

Cost of permit, cost of my visa run to not overstay while waiting for the visa to be processed.

**Did you pay the visa / permit costs or were they covered by your organization?**

The permit costs were covered by Baylor, and PiAf assisted with my visa run costs.

**Are you still having challenges obtaining your visa/ permit?**

No

**If yes, please explain further**

**g) Do you have any suggestions to help future Fellows navigate the visa / permit application process?**

Make sure Baylor applies very early for you, and be proactive in initiating this process before you arrive.

**What vaccinations were you required to obtain prior to your departure? How much did your vaccinations cost? Did you get a yellow fever vaccination?**

No additional vaccines needed, I already had yellow fever.

**How was your arrival and first week in your host country? Any improvements that could streamline the assimilation process for future Fellows?**

My housing is provided by Baylor. I stay in a small two bedroom two bathroom house in Area 3 and I am the only one there. It was furnished when I arrived, and everything is covered by Baylor.

**Is housing provided by and/or paid for by your organization? Please explain.**

My housing is provided by Baylor. I stay in a small two bedroom two bathroom house in Area 3 and I am the only one there. It was furnished when I arrived, and everything is covered by Baylor.

**Do you live in a location that is more urban or rural?**

Very Urban

**Please describe your living environment**

My living environment is quite secure and comfortable. My house is on a property with maybe 8 other small houses, and lots of fruit trees. Area 3 is a little less safe now, so I try to avoid walking around after dark there but I haven't had any issues.

**How do you typically travel between your home and your work? How much does your daily transportation cost and how long is your commute?**

I use a car to travel to and from work, and just pay for gas. I probably pay around \$250-300/month for gas. The commute is 15-25 minutes depending on traffic.

**If you live in a more rural area, what are the closest urban areas you can travel to for shopping, airport, larger medical centers, etc.?**

I live in an urban area. The airport is 45 min away, while medical centers and shopping are 10 minutes away.

**How is the weather in your host country? What season are you presently in?**

The weather is hot during the day, but sometimes cools down at night. It isn't very humid. Right now we are in the rainy season, so the mornings are very hot and sunny and then most afternoons we have a big rainstorm.

**What is the appropriate clothing for work and outside of work at your fellowship post and in your community in general?**

At the hospital, attire is pretty formal. Women wear skirts/blouses, dresses or work pants. In Lilongwe more broadly, attire is usually a little more conservative for both men and women. Women wear mid-length or floor-length skirts or pants, not shorts, and often cover their shoulders. Men wear pants and shirts. I feel comfortable running in long basketball shorts but I only do it in Area 10 (more of an expat neighborhood). When I'm doing athletics that require less clothes, like climbing in shorts or spandex, I usually wear a skirt on top until I'm at the climbing center or hike, and then take it off when I enter the center. For boys, I think athletic shorts are fine for adventures.

**How have you been spending your free time?**

The social scene in Lilongwe is quite small, but welcoming. During my freetime I swim, hike, climb, camp and hang out at the houses of my friends. Sometimes we also go to the lake. It's really easy to meet people here because there are lots of activities for newcomers to join. I met most of my friends through the climbing center Climb Malawi, but I know other people who go to the weekly volleyball, frisbee, handball or soccer games too. The climbing center is my favorite though because there are many Malawians as well as visitors, so the social scene is a bit

more balanced. There are also some restaurants where expats go for different events like Thursdays at La Cantina and Sunday night jazz at the Four Seasons which would be an easy way to meet foreigners, but I don't usually partake in that.

**I've been able to successfully navigate my personal/social life both back at home and at my fellowship post.**

Strongly Agree

**Please briefly explain your response below.**

I have been out of the US since June 2022 so I'm pretty used to meeting new people as well as keeping up with my old friends.

**Would you say you live and work in a safe area?**

Lilongwe is very safe. I have heard about a bit of petty crime, but it isn't more than you would find in Washington, DC, for example (where I'm from). The only downside is the lack of street lights at night. In Area 3 where I stay, I've been told I really shouldn't walk around after dark (especially because I am white so it's hard to go unnoticed). But since I have a car to use for the time being, that hasn't been limiting. The property where I stay with my neighbors has 24/7 guards which is very common.

**What precautions do you take to ensure your safety?**

Since I stay alone, I am very careful about locking my house. If I want to go to a more dangerous neighborhood, especially at night, I make sure to bring a Malawian friend.

**What has been your experience with crime so far? (Please note that any security or safety concerns or incidents should be reported directly to PiAf staff per PiAf safety and security protocol.)**

I haven't had any experiences with crime, but I did have a friend who went away last weekend and had a break in where they stole her work computer. She lives a couple blocks from me.

**Describe the incidence of crime and the general security situation within your city/town. Could you recommend specific areas future Fellows might consider for safe housing? What about areas that should be avoided?**

Area 3 is totally fine for crime. If you want a very safe neighborhood, you can look at the fancier areas like Area 43 or Area 10. The downside there is that you can end up in an expat bubble, whereas I live right in the middle of things and can walk around to local markets and shops easily during the day.

**Please refer back to the goals you set for yourself before orientation. Are you working towards these goals? Have you met any of them? Changed any of them? Please explain.**

Having dealt with some pretty intense health issues at the start of my fellowship, which complicated my first few months, my goals became a bit more conservative for this year. But I do feel as though I've been able to learn a bit about what it means to deliver high-quality clinical work in a low-resourced setting, which was my main goal in coming to do the fellowship!

**Do you have any frustrations with your living arrangements, your work or your life outside of work?**

I have had some trouble with my supervisor at work, but I have been able to chat with PiAf staff and my alumni mentor for support which helped me navigate some of these situations!

**Has there been anything that you have needed but have not been able to locate or acquire?**

No, I have had friends who travel to Europe for work/to visit family bring me anything I couldn't get here.

**How have you dealt with "culture shock"?**

I haven't had any issues with culture shock to be honest.

**What about your experience thus far has been the most...surprising?**

There have been some odd political events recently which are impacting life here. Mainly, the vice president was killed right before I arrived and many people suspect that his death was orchestrated by the current president. The kwacha also keeps fluctuating in value, many Malawians have been blocked by the major banks from using their international currencies (mainly USD). These forex issues have also led to two very substantial fuel crises. A few weeks ago I spent 3 hours waiting for gas from 4am so that I could refuel on week 5 of the fuel shortage, and had to go to work straight after. So, things have been quite interesting!

**What about your experience thus far has been the most...challenging?**

Here in Malawi, race is an element of every interaction I have. When I walk outside, people stare at me. In the markets or rural areas, I've had multiple instances where I wave at a toddler and they throw a fit because they are scared of me. In the rural areas, kids will shout "muzungu, muzungu!" (foreigner/white person in Chichewa) every time they see me, and many adults even call me muzungu to my face. In a Ministry of Health meeting I also heard a doctor argue that "Africans are biologically different from Europeans."

There is also a huge perception of white people being super rich. I get asked for money a lot, even for \$100 bills from my colleagues because the USD has so much power here right now against the kwacha. I don't come from a very well off background and at the beginning of my fellowship I had to pay for some unexpected health-related expenses which left me with very limited money for a few months. There is a lot of poverty here, and relatively I am better off. But the perceptions are quite exaggerated. For example, once when I mentioned to my boss that I could not afford something, she got angry and said she didn't believe me. Like any bias, it is tiring to be viewed in a way that feels misinformed.

But it's also nice to be able to slowly shift people's misconceptions. Eating nsima with my hand or eating from shared plates with my colleagues, people will literally say "Oh, I didn't know white people could do that." I can be a bit tiring over time to be in a society that isn't very racially diverse, but through my actions, I try to slowly break down that perceived barrier of separation.

**What are the top 3 things you miss the most from your home country or the U.S.?**

Good cheese, hint of lime tostitos, libraries

**What are the top 3 things about life in your host country that beat out life in your home country or the U.S.?**

Easily accessible fresh fruits and vegetables, kind people wherever you go, warm weather and places to swim!

**How is your stipend being paid?**

Monthly stipend in USD from PiAf to my bank account.

**How are you receiving your stipend funds?**

ACH

**Did you raise funds to cover part of your fellowship expenses?**

I have two tutoring jobs, one online and one in person, in addition to my fellowship in order to cover my costs (especially my flight back home this December for the holidays).

**Please list any additional one-time or infrequent expenses not included in your monthly budget below.**

Monthly Budget

|                        |                                    |                      |                  |                       |                                                                |
|------------------------|------------------------------------|----------------------|------------------|-----------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Rent</b>            | <b>Utilities</b>                   | <b>Furnishings</b>   | <b>Phone</b>     | <b>Home Security</b>  | <b>Internet</b>                                                |
| \$0.00                 | \$0.00                             | \$10.00              | \$10.00          | \$0.00                | \$19.98                                                        |
| <b>Transportation</b>  | <b>Fitness</b>                     | <b>Entertainment</b> | <b>Groceries</b> | <b>House Cleaning</b> | <b>Eating Out</b>                                              |
| \$300.00               | \$40.00                            | \$20.00              | \$250.00         | \$40.00               | \$30.00                                                        |
| <b>Medications</b>     | <b>Additional Health Insurance</b> | <b>Travel</b>        | <b>Laundry</b>   | <b>Other</b>          | <b>Total Monthly Budget (Minus Entertainment &amp; Travel)</b> |
| \$40.00                | \$0.00                             | \$80.00              | \$5.00           | \$0.00                | 744.98                                                         |
| <b>Specify "Other"</b> |                                    |                      |                  |                       |                                                                |

## Final Thoughts

**Please briefly explain your response about Orientation.**

Orientation did provide sufficient preparation.

**Is there anything in particular that PiAf could cover at orientation that would have better prepared you for your fellowship post? Please specify.**

It would have been nice to have a bit of a more extensive conversation about identity surrounding the PiAf fellowship, including conversations about race, class, gender, sexuality and how those identities might impact our experience. We had a lecture in the first few months on it, but it wasn't much of a discussion and I think it would've been nice to find a way to involve all of the fellows instead of having it be optional.

**Are you receiving sufficient support, materials and information from the Princeton in Africa office? What could we improve?**

I have received sufficient support from PiAf in line with my expectations from the contract.

**As we plan the upcoming PiAf Retreat, we hope to incorporate some Fellow suggestions into our programming. What are some topics or sessions you would like to see at the Retreat? (We appreciate your feedback however, we may not be able to accommodate all suggestions or requests this year.)**

This is more general, but the orientation was very focused on American fellows, and even had moments that felt very biased against the African fellows (for example, the health talk about all the diseases you could get on the continent). I would hope that we could put more of an effort into having the mid-year retreat be less Americanized.